

Paperwork 3-Folder System

Module 3 — Complete Document Sorting Guide

Sort every piece of paper in the house into one of three folders. This guide tells you exactly what goes where and how long to keep it.

DOCUMENTS TO LOCATE FIRST

Before sorting anything else, find these. They are needed for every other module.

Document	Why It's Critical	Found?
Will / Living Will	Controls estate and medical decisions	■
Power of Attorney (Financial)	Authorizes someone to manage finances	■
Power of Attorney (Healthcare)	Authorizes someone to make medical decisions	■
Property Deed / Title	Required for any home sale	■
Mortgage Statement	Shows what's owed on the home	■
Insurance Policies (all)	Home, auto, health, life, LTC	■
Social Security Cards	Identity verification for everything	■
Birth Certificates	Identity, benefits, legal proceedings	■

FOLDER 1: KEEP

Document Type	How Long to Keep	■
Wills, trusts, POAs	Permanently	■
Birth / death certificates	Permanently	■
Social Security cards	Permanently	■
Marriage / divorce papers	Permanently	■
Military discharge (DD-214)	Permanently	■
Property deeds / titles	As long as owned + 7 years	■
Tax returns + support docs	7 years from filing date	■
Active insurance policies	While active + 3 years	■
Recent medical records	3-7 years (varies by state)	■
Investment / retirement stmts	Keep annual summaries permanently	■
Vehicle titles	As long as owned	■
Pension / annuity contracts	Permanently	■
Loan agreements (active)	Until paid off + 7 years	■

FOLDER 2: ACTION

- Unpaid bills
- Forms that need to be completed

- Insurance claims to file
- Correspondence that needs a response
- Subscriptions to cancel
- Accounts to close or transfer

Review this folder weekly. Goal: empty.

FOLDER 3: SHRED

- Old bank statements (keep last 12 months only)
- Credit card offers and junk mail with personal info
- Outdated medical bills (paid and resolved)
- Old insurance policies (expired / replaced)
- Tax returns older than 7 years
- Pay stubs (keep last year only if still employed)
- Old utility bills
- Expired warranties and manuals

SHRED, don't trash. Any document with a name, SSN, account number, or address must be shredded.

DIGITAL BACKUP

- Scan or photograph all KEEP folder documents
- Upload to your SeniorSafe document vault (app.seniorsafeapp.com)
- Store physical originals in a fireproof file box or safe deposit box
- Share vault access with designated family members